



Both Yogi Adityanath of the Bharatiya Janata Party and Akhilesh Yadav of the Samajwadi Party have completed a term each as chief minister of India's most populous state. Now, they head into an electoral battle in which they are the primary contenders. In interviews with Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa half way through the polls, they shared their assessments of the election so far and their views on key issues in the contest. Excerpts:

Q. Half-way through the assembly election, what do you see as the main electoral issues?

YOGI ADITYANATH: The main issue in UP is security, the rule of law. Who can guarantee security to every person, provide a riot- and fear-free environment, freedom from all kinds of hooliganism and anarchy? The double-engine government of the Bharatiya Janata Party has created an environment in the state where every person feels safe and protected. Freedom is guaranteed, every person is respected and it is linked to the welfare schemes of the government. I am happy that we have been able to serve the people under the leadership and guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

AKHILESH YADAV: The double-engine *sarkar* will be derailed this time; people will not let them win. In the past five years, the Yogi government promised so much, but did not deliver. They promised 70 lakh jobs they could not deliver, they had investor meets, but